Nominalization and abstract nouns

Understand it

Nominalization turns actions (verbs) and qualities (adjectives) into nouns. Academic English uses it to pack information densely: Because prices rose quickly → The rapid rise in prices.

When you read a dense sentence, turn the nouns back into verbs to understand who did what.

The rules

- Academic texts turn verbs and adjectives into nouns: to increase quickly = a rapid increase; to decide = a decision; important = importance.
- This packs more information into fewer words: Because prices rose, people bought less = The rise in prices reduced consumption.
- Common noun suffixes: -tion, -ment, -ance, -ity, -ness, -ism.
- When reading, turn the noun back into a verb to understand: the development of = developing.

All the words and forms you need

Verb → noun	develop → development · reduce → reduction · grow → growth · decide → decision · analyze → analysis · fail → failure · arrive → arrival
Adjective → noun	important → importance · able → ability · difficult → difficulty · accurate → accuracy · available → availability · poor → poverty
Typical academic nouns	impact · factor · trend · outcome · consequence · approach · aspect · process · issue · tendency
Patterns	the + noun + of + noun · a / the + adjective + noun · there has been a + noun + in

Where you use it

Reading: Passage 3 uses many abstract nouns. Convert them back to verbs in your head.

Listening: Lecturers use nouns like trend, factor, impact, outcome.

Writing: One nominalization per paragraph raises the register.

Speaking: Keep the verbs: do not over-formalize.

More examples

- The introduction of the new law caused protests.
- There has been a significant reduction in crime.
- The availability of cheap flights increased tourism.
- A lack of exercise contributes to obesity.

- The analysis of the data took six months.
- Their failure to act led to the crisis.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ The grow of cities is fast.	✓ The growth of cities is fast.
✗ A decide was made.	✓ A decision was made.
✗ The important of sleep.	✓ The importance of sleep.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. What is the biggest problem in your city? (use a noun: the lack of ..., the rise in ...)
2. What has been the most important development in technology?
3. What is the impact of tourism on your country?

Writing practice

Rewrite with nouns: People spend less, so shops close. / The city grew fast, which caused pollution.

Practice

1. Noun from develop: _____
2. Noun from reduce: _____
3. Noun from important: _____
4. Rewrite with a noun: People became poorer, which caused unrest. _____
5. Rewrite: Because the climate changed, species moved. _____
6. Correct: The able to adapt is key. _____

Answers

1. development
2. reduction
3. importance
4. Growing poverty caused unrest.
5. Climate change caused species to move.
6. The ability to adapt is key.